Carnatic Music

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Introduction to Carnatic Music

Carnatic music is the classical music tradition of South India, particularly of Tamil Nadu, Karnataka, Andhra Pradesh, Telangana and Kerala. It is one of the two main systems of Indian classical music, the other being Hindustani music of North India. Carnatic music is mostly devotional and compositional, with an emphasis on vocal music, and even the instruments imitate the human voice (gayaki style). It is based on the ideas of melody (raga) and rhythm (tala) and is traditionally taught through the guru-shishya system, where students learn directly from a teacher. The tradition is thought to go back to ancient texts such as the Natya Shastra and the Tamil Sangam literature, and it took its modern shape between the 14th and 19th centuries.

What Are Raga and Tala?

A raga is the melodic framework of Indian music. It is more than a scale: it is a set of notes (swaras) arranged with rules for how they ascend (arohana) and descend (avarohana), with characteristic phrases, ornaments called gamakas and emphasised notes, which together create a particular mood or emotion (rasa). The seven basic notes are Sa, Ri, Ga, Ma, Pa, Dha and Ni, called the sapta swaras. Ragas are arranged in a system of 72 parent scales called melakarta ragas, from which numerous derived ragas, called janya ragas, are formed. Examples of well-known ragas are Mayamalavagowla, the first raga learned by beginners, Shankarabharanam, Kalyani, Todi, Bhairavi, Kharaharapriya and Mohanam. Some ragas are linked with times of the day or seasons. A raga is explored in an improvised introduction called alapana.

A tala is the rhythmic cycle that measures time in music. It is made up of a fixed number of beats (aksharas) that repeat in a cycle called an avartana, and it is shown by hand claps, finger counts and waves. The most common tala is Adi tala, with eight beats, and other common ones include Rupaka tala with three beats, Misra chapu with seven beats and Khanda chapu with five beats. The system of seven basic tala families (Suladi Sapta Tala) with 35 variations is used. Percussion instruments such as the mridangam, ghatam and kanjira follow and enrich the tala. Together, raga and tala form the foundation of every composition and improvisation, called manodharma, in Carnatic music. Another feature is the drone, produced by the tambura, which provides the reference note, shruti.

Who Are the Trinity of Carnatic Music?

The Trinity of Carnatic Music, called the Trimurti, are three great composers who lived in the late 18th and early 19th centuries and were all born in Tiruvarur in the Thanjavur region of Tamil Nadu: Tyagaraja (1767 to 1847), Muthuswami Dikshitar (1775 to 1835) and Syama Sastri (1762 to 1827). Tyagaraja, who composed thousands of devotional songs, called kritis, in Telugu praising Lord Rama, is most famous for the Pancharatna Kritis, the five gem songs, and lived in Thiruvaiyaru, where his annual Aradhana festival is held in January. Muthuswami Dikshitar composed in Sanskrit, with deep spiritual content and very rich ragas, and his songs on the temples of Tiruvarur and Chidambaram and the Navagraha kritis are famous, and he signed his songs with "Guruguha". Syama Sastri composed mostly in Telugu and is known for his swarajatis and for his songs to the goddess Meenakshi and Kamakshi. Earlier, Purandara Dasa (1484 to 1564) is regarded as the "Pitamaha", or grandfather of Carnatic music for creating its teaching system of basic lessons such as the sarali varisai. Other great figures include Annamacharya, Kshetrayya, Swathi Thirunal, Gopalakrishna Bharati and Arunachala Kavi.

Forms and Instruments

Important musical forms include the varnam, a composition that is the centrepiece of a concert and a training piece, the kriti, the most popular form, the keertanam, the padam and javali, love songs used in dance, the tillana, a rhythmic piece usually ending a concert, and the Ragam-Tanam-Pallavi, a complex improvised piece. Instruments include the veena, the Saraswati's instrument, the violin, introduced into Carnatic music in the 18th century by Baluswami Dikshitar, the flute, the mridangam, the barrel drum that is the main percussion, the ghatam (clay pot), the kanjira, the morsing and the tambura. The saxophone and mandolin have also been adapted by artists such as Kadri Gopalnath and U. Srinivas.

What Is the Chennai December Music Season?

The Chennai December Music Season, also called the Margazhi season, is a festival of Carnatic music and Bharatanatyam dance that is held every year from mid-December to mid-January, mostly during the Tamil month of Margazhi (December to January), when hundreds of concerts, lecture-demonstrations and dance programmes are given in sabhas (music associations) and auditoriums around Chennai. The tradition began in 1927 when a music conference was held in Madras at the same time as the Indian National Congress session, which led to the founding of the Madras Music Academy in 1928. Today, the season has more than 1,000 performances by hundreds of artists, from young newcomers to legendary masters, with many sabhas such as the Music Academy, Narada Gana Sabha, Krishna Gana Sabha, Mylapore Fine Arts Club and Brahma Gana Sabha. The Music Academy confers the title Sangita Kalanidhi on the most distinguished musician of the year, and the season also includes the traditional Kutcheri, the concert format, and canteens known for their food. It attracts rasikas, or connoisseurs, and visitors from India and abroad, and it is considered one of the largest cultural events in the world.

Famous Carnatic Musicians

Well-known artists include M. S. Subbulakshmi of Madurai, the first musician to receive the Bharat Ratna (in 1998), who performed at the United Nations General Assembly in 1966, Semmangudi Srinivasa Iyer, M. L. Vasanthakumari, D. K. Pattammal, M. Balamuralikrishna, K. J. Yesudas, T. N. Seshagopalan, Lalgudi Jayaraman, Palghat Mani Iyer, Sudha Ragunathan, T. M. Krishna and Bombay Jayashri. The film composer Ilaiyaraaja and A. R. Rahman, both from Chennai, have Carnatic roots. The Tamil Isai Sangam promotes Tamil songs in concerts.

Learning and Recognition

Students begin with basic exercises, such as sarali varisai, janta varisai, alankaras, then geethams, varnams and kritis, practicing at dawn, with training from a guru for many years. The Sangeet Natak Akademi and Padma awards honour musicians, and Carnatic music is taught at colleges such as the Government Music Colleges and Kalakshetra.

Challenges and Future

Challenges include reaching younger audiences and balancing tradition with new ideas. Online concerts, fusion with other genres and global interest are widening its reach.

Quick Facts

- A raga is a melodic framework of notes with rules and mood; a tala is a rhythmic cycle of beats.

- The Trinity of Carnatic music are Tyagaraja, Muthuswami Dikshitar and Syama Sastri, all born in Tiruvarur.
- The Chennai December Music Season is held from mid-December to mid-January, with the Music Academy founded in 1928.
- Carnatic music has 72 melakarta parent ragas.
- Purandara Dasa is called the Pitamaha of Carnatic music.